SOUND & SONG DESIGN

Song Design: Music, Lyric and the Nigerian Stage

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

Writing songs that carry a story: the function of a number, verse and chorus, the band, and the traditions a Nigerian musical can draw on.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- the function of a song
- lyric writing
- arrangement
- the band
- Nigerian traditions

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A song in a play must do something

A number in a musical works when it does what speech cannot: a character who cannot say what they want sings it, or a company that cannot agree sings its disagreement. If the scene would survive with the song cut, the song is decoration.

Decide the function before writing a note: the "I want" song, the love duet, the comic list, the eleven o'clock number, the reprise that closes the argument. Each has a place in the shape of the evening.

Lyric before melody, then both together

Write the lyric as a speech first. If it is not worth saying, it will not be worth singing. Then find the stress pattern: the natural emphasis of the words becomes the rhythm, and a melody that fights the stress will make the words incomprehensible however good the tune.

A chorus is a repeated idea with a new meaning each time. The best reprises change one word, and the audience hears the whole story in that word.

Arrangement and the band

Write for the musicians you have. A keyboard, a guitar, a bass, drums and two singers will carry most shows, and a good arrangement for six players beats a thin arrangement for twenty. Decide the key for the voice, not for the instrument, and transpose rather than asking a singer to strain.

The band needs a score, a click where the tempo is tricky, and a conductor who can see the stage. Put the band where the actors can hear it; in a small hall that usually means the side of the stage, not a pit.

What a Nigerian musical can draw on

The traditions are deep and usable: highlife and palmwine guitar with their interlocking lines, the call-and-response of Yoruba and Igbo work songs, the talking drum's speech patterns, church choral harmony, Fuji and Afrobeat rhythm. A song that quotes a tradition should quote it accurately and credit it.

Folk opera is the local precedent: music, dance, spectacle and a moral argument in one evening. Study how those productions move from speech into song and back, because the transitions are where most student musicals fail.

Where the songs sit in the story

Map the evening before writing a note. A conventional shape: an opening number that introduces the world, a want song for the protagonist, a duet that complicates the relationship, an act-one finale that raises the stakes, a comic number after the interval, an eleven o'clock song for the protagonist alone, and a finale that resolves the argument.

That shape is not a rule, but it is a diagnosis. If your show has no want song, the audience does not know what the protagonist wants. If it has no act-one finale, the interval has nothing to think about. If the finale introduces new material, the show has not finished.

Write the transitions before the songs. The move from speech into music is where an audience decides whether to accept the form; a scene that simply stops and a band that simply starts will lose them. Give the band a cue in the dialogue, give the actor a reason to sing, and rehearse the join until it is invisible.

Rehearsing a number

Rehearse a song in three passes: learn the notes and the words, learn the staging, then put them together slowly. Most student numbers fail because the company learned the choreography before it could sing the tune, and the singing never recovered.

Then rehearse it with the band, with the microphones and in costume, before the technical rehearsal. A number that has never met its band is a number that will be conducted by panic on the first night.

Exercises

1. Take a scene with no song and write the "I want" number it needs, with one verse and a chorus.
2. Set the same lyric in two rhythms - a highlife feel and a slow ballad - and compare what each says.
3. Score a two-minute number for the instruments your department actually owns.

Where to read more

Deena Kaye and James LeBrecht, Sound and Music for the Theatre (2009)

Lehman Engel, The American Musical Theater (1967)

Yemi Ogunbiyi (ed.), Drama and Theatre in Nigeria (1981)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.